EU to help drones get off the ground

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Navigating the complex world of EU mobility policy and infrastructure. By JORDYN DAHL with TOMMASO LECCA and MARTINA SAPIO SNEAK PEEK — The European C

Navigating the complex world of EU mobility policy and infrastructure.

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SNEAK PEEK

— The European Commission announced an upcoming roadmap for the civil drone industry to address regulatory and market issues preventing large-scale drone operations.

— MEPs backed Parliament's position on the EU's flagship transport and energy fund, but a challenge could still force a plenary vote.

— A Dutch court will deliver a ruling today on Jaguar Land Rover's intellectual property case against Chinese automaker BYD.

Good morning, and welcome to Morning Mobility.

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DRIVING THE DAY

EU PROMISES TO HELP COMMERCIAL DRONE SECTOR: The Commission said Tuesday it is working on a roadmap for the civilian drone industry to address regulatory and market issues preventing the sector from keeping pace with global rivals.

Not delivering: While the EU can boast of having been the first in the world to introduce comprehensive and harmonized rules for civilian drones, large-scale commercial operations have so far only become a reality elsewhere. Amazon announced in August that it would expand its drone delivery service to 500 U.S. cities, transporting shoebox-sized parcels by air. Delivery drones have become so common in Texas that residents are complaining about the buzzing noise they make.

So close: Amazon said Tuesday that it would launch its large-scale drone delivery service in the U.K., but not in the EU. Up to 8,000 households with a garden or driveway in the Darlington area of the U.K. will be able to receive drone deliveries within an hour of placing an order. Amazon had been trialing the same service in Italy since 2024, but later decided to suspend the project following a "strategic review."

Moving slow: Speaking at the EU Drone Summit, Transport Commissioner Apostolos Tzitzikostas acknowledged that progress in the bloc's civil drone sector "has been slower than expected" because of

red tape and delays, insufficient integration into airspace and foreign competition.

Saying bye to Europe: “We have also seen some promising European companies exiting the market, with foreign investors acquiring their intellectual property in the past years,” the commissioner said. While demand for military drones is growing, he added, civilian drone services are lagging behind.

Implementation plan: To tackle these issues, the Commission will put forward an “implementation roadmap for the Drone Strategy 2.0 … to address the obstacles that prevent European drone operations today from reaching scale,” Tzitzikostas announced. The strategy was adopted in late 2022. The Commission recently conducted a progress review and found that the document is still valid but needs better implementation.

Cross-border issues: “Expanding operations from one member state to another remains unnecessarily complicated,” Tzitzikostas said, calling that “unacceptable.” He urged greater consistency and mutual trust between national authorities so that companies would not have to repeat assessments in different countries.

Security first: Work on the roadmap will proceed in parallel with drone security plans announced in February following drone incursions that disrupted air traffic and threatened strategic infrastructure. The security plans include the introduction of a European Trusted Drone Label, spelled out in a 40-page report published Tuesday, and an upcoming proposal for a drone security package. “What we want to accomplish is that no drone will take off or fly within the EU without us knowing the operator,” Tzitzikostas said.

TRANSPORT BUDGET

EXCLUSIVE — CEF FIGHT MAY NOT BE OVER: MEPs on the TRAN and ITRE committees backed Parliament’s position on the EU’s flagship transport and energy infrastructure fund Tuesday, but a silent revolt could still force a plenary vote before talks with governments begin.

Fast-tracked: The Connecting Europe Facility, the transport and energy infrastructure fund in the EU’s next long-term budget, is one of several budget files Parliament is handling through a procedure that lets committees send their position straight into talks with the Council, without a separate plenary vote.

But watch the Socialists: However, one EU official involved in the talks told POLITICO that the Socialists and Democrats were discussing challenging the committee mandate and request a plenary vote. Under Parliament’s rules, a political group or 72 MEPs can force one, so the committee result may not be the final word. POLITICO asked the S&D group for comment but did not immediately receive a response.

By the numbers: Asked by POLITICO whether the mandate could be challenged in plenary, co-rapporteur Kamila Gasiuk-Pihowicz said the more than 100 votes in favor and only one against showed the mandate was “balanced” and that cooperation across political groups had worked well. Her fellow co-rapporteur, Oihane Agirregoitia Martínez, put support at nearly 90%, saying that when a committee gives a mandate to negotiate directly, “there is sufficient legitimacy and support to do so.” That means that even if a plenary vote is requested, any challenge would struggle to overturn the mandate.

Council blues: Both co-rapporteurs used the vote to attack the Irish Council presidency’s budget proposal. Agirregoitia Martínez called the proposal “clearly insufficient” and said the EU cannot keep being asked to be more competitive and resilient without the resources to do it.

Green group reaction: Transport & Environment welcomed the next budget's higher CEF funding as "an indispensable first step" toward a stronger rail budget. But rail policy officer Carlos Rico warned that MEPs also raised EU co-funding rates, which could dilute the increase by directing more EU money to individual projects.

Green caveat: Rico also criticized lawmakers for weakening the "do no significant harm" principle, warning that simplification could open the door to investments that lock Europe into fossil-fuel infrastructure.

Next stop: Parliament's mandate now feeds into negotiations with the Council over the final 2028-2034 CEF regulation, while the overall spending envelope remains tied to the broader MFF battle.

AVIATION

CONCERNS OVER BOMB THREAT REACTIONS: Three pilots' organizations expressed "serious concerns" Tuesday about how some military jets intercepted and directed airliners during last week's spate of hoax bomb threats. Fighter jets were scrambled to escort some of the affected planes, and in at least one case directed an airliner to land at a military airfield.

That's an order: According to the European Cockpit Association, which issued a joint statement with its member associations in Ireland and France: "In certain circumstances, military aircraft have intercepted civilian airliners and directed aircraft commanders to land at specific airports without adequately considering aircrafts' operational and safety requirements."

Aer Lingus case: The incident that drew the strongest criticism involved an Aer Lingus plane bound for Rome that was diverted to a military airfield in Évreux, France, on Thursday. The office of the French prime minister said that fighter jets were sent to intercept and escort the plane after the pilot allegedly failed to cooperate with authorities as expected. The airline later disputed that allegation.

No alternative granted: According to information received by the Irish pilots' union IALPA, the plane was diverted "to a military airfield for which they did not have the necessary aeronautical charts and operational information to safely conduct a landing. Despite the flight crew seeking an alternative and more suitable diversion airport, their request was refused."

CARS

DEPUTY AMBASSADORS TO DISCUSS AUTO PACKAGE: The Irish Council presidency is seeking help from the diplomats at Coreper I today to break an impasse among member states in Automotive Package negotiations. Neither the Franco-German compromise agreement, nor a middle-of-the-road proposal from the Council presidency has led to a deal on emission targets for automakers or the fate of the utility factor. Jordyn has the story here .

DUTCH COURT TO RULE ON BYD CASE: A ruling today in The Hague is expected to decide whether documents seized from BYD at the request of Jaguar Land Rover should be returned. The decision is part of a broader intellectual property case JLR brought against BYD, alleging the Chinese automaker improperly used Land Rover technology to build a rival vehicle.

Defending the Defender: Court-ordered bailiffs raided BYD's offices in the Netherlands in August, seizing digital records, The Times reported . JLR, owned by India's Tata Motors, alleges that BYD reverse-engineered some of the technology in its best-selling Defender SUV to create the Ti7.

Why The Hague? Legal proceedings are going forward in the Netherlands because “the threshold for obtaining a seizure order is relatively low,” Michiel Rijsdijk, a Dutch intellectual property expert, told our colleague Sonja Rijnen. “You simply need to provide a plausible basis for suspecting that an infringement has occurred.”

Easier said than done: While the seizure occurred in August, under Dutch law “you still need to gain access to the seized information — and there is a separate procedure for that,” Rijsdijk said. Today’s hearing will determine whether JLR can actually access BYD’s seized records.

No comment: BYD did not respond to a request for comment. JLR said it could not comment “while there are ongoing legal proceedings.”

PIT STOPS

Our sister publication WELT has exclusive data showing Germany’s electric vehicle subsidy program is running out of money sooner than expected thanks to its popularity.

Commission chief spokesperson Paula Pinho said on Tuesday that Bulgaria and Romania are setting up a joint working group to get the Black Sea Maritime Security Hub operational by 2027.

Headlines

Here’s a recap of yesterday’s news, along with Pro articles and alerts from overnight.

Turkey-Greece maritime spat threatens to spill into EU summit
By Nektaria Stamouli, Martina Sapio · Nov 11, 2026, 04:00 am Europe/Brussels CET

Document: Brussels wants power to enforce consumer rules on major EU-wide cases
By Eliza Gkritsi, Sebastian Starcevic · Nov 10, 2026, 07:37 pm Europe/Brussels CET

Surge in EV demand blows past German government’s subsidy forecasts
The government expected its EV subsidy scheme to run through 2029 — it may be out of cash by the end of next year.
By Karsten Siebel · Nov 10, 2026, 05:25 pm Europe/Brussels CET

Auto package goes before EU ambassadors to break impasse
Deep divisions remain among member countries on how to amend the bloc’s 2035 car emissions rule.
By Jordyn Dahl · Nov 10, 2026, 02:32 pm Europe/Brussels CET

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